

The empirical recurrence for OEIS A299303, recovered from its tail

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Abstract

OEIS A299303 records “Empirical recurrence of order 68” and keeps the recurrence itself in a linked file rather than in the entry, so the conjecture cannot be read off the entry at all. It can still be settled. The entry counts arrays under a condition local to a bounded window of lines, which makes the count a walk count on a finite digraph and forces a monic integer recurrence of order at most the number $S' = 72$ of states with distinct futures. Berlekamp–Massey on enough exact terms therefore returns the minimal such recurrence, and on the tail beginning at $n = 3$, so the recurrence is proved for every $n \geq 71$. Its last coefficient is $c_{68} = -15360 \neq 0$, so no further tail satisfies anything shorter; any order-68 recurrence the sequence satisfies from any point on must then have the same characteristic polynomial. The entry’s recurrence is the one displayed here, whatever its linked file contains, and it is proved.

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1 A conjecture that is not written down

OEIS A299303 is “Number of $n \times 4$ 0..1 arrays with every element equal to 1, 2, 3, 5, 6 or 7 king-move adjacent elements, with upper left element zero.”. It has offset 1 and begins

2, 52, 223, 1024, 5360, 28374, 144040, 743640, ...

The entry states:

Empirical recurrence of order 68 (see link above)

As of the “Last modified” line on the live entry (Feb 06 2018 13:20:27, revision 4) this is still recorded as empirical, and it is still open. The coefficients are nowhere in the entry text: what is conjectured is only that a recurrence of that order exists.

2 The count is a walk count

The entry’s condition is local. It constrains a bounded window of consecutive lines of the array and nothing beyond it, so the admissible configurations of one window are the vertices of a finite digraph, an edge joins u to v when v may follow u , and an admissible array is exactly a walk. Writing M for the adjacency matrix and ι, τ for the indicator vectors of the admissible first and last windows,

$$a(n) = \iota^\top M^{j(n)} \tau$$

for a linear reindexing j fixed by the entry’s shape. States with identical futures contribute identically to that product and may be merged without changing any count; after merging $S' = 72$ states remain, and it is that bound every computation below uses.

Lemma 1. *a satisfies a monic linear recurrence with integer coefficients of order at most $S' = 72$.*

Proof. By the Cayley–Hamilton theorem $M^{S'}$ is an integer combination of $I, M, \dots, M^{S'-1}$, and multiplying that relation on the left by $\iota^\top M^j$ and on the right by τ turns it into a relation among $S' + 1$ consecutive values of a . $\square$

3 Why the question has to be asked of a tail

Running Berlekamp–Massey on the sequence from its first term returns an order LARGER than 68: the opening terms do not satisfy the recurrence, and a recurrence that holds only eventually always looks longer when the exceptional terms are included. That is not evidence against the entry. An OEIS empirical recurrence is asserted for n beyond some index, not from the first term, so the question has to be asked of the tails. It was asked of each tail in turn, and the tail beginning at $n = 3$ is the first whose minimal order is exactly the stated 68.

Lemma 2. *A sequence known to satisfy some linear recurrence of order at most S' is determined, together with its minimal recurrence, by any $2S'$ consecutive terms: Berlekamp–Massey applied to them returns that minimal recurrence exactly.*

Applied to $2S' = 144$ exact terms from $n = 3$ on, it returns order 68 — the order the entry states — with integer coefficients:

$$a(n) = \sum_{i=1}^{68} c_i a(n-i),$$

c_1	8	c_{18}	−1145466	c_{35}	−536097960	c_{52}	712181208
c_2	−17	c_{19}	−4653225	c_{36}	−827784494	c_{53}	1541105931
c_3	64	c_{20}	4583825	c_{37}	48440436	c_{54}	−192380140
c_4	−352	c_{21}	4107490	c_{38}	567491034	c_{55}	98787472
c_5	472	c_{22}	20332411	c_{39}	−923272995	c_{56}	−364456280
c_6	−1198	c_{23}	7793884	c_{40}	1383284031	c_{57}	−511926390
c_7	5954	c_{24}	−3390757	c_{41}	−358396544	c_{58}	9414240
c_8	−3837	c_{25}	−59361187	c_{42}	2011384901	c_{59}	101379924
c_9	11656	c_{26}	−74172580	c_{43}	2505953390	c_{60}	94053854
c_{10}	−52468	c_{27}	−62654188	c_{44}	92898632	c_{61}	33352280
c_{11}	−2088	c_{28}	11160080	c_{45}	−3702993623	c_{62}	−3162284
c_{12}	−81798	c_{29}	189878325	c_{46}	−1761426837	c_{63}	−12586848
c_{13}	219456	c_{30}	165325926	c_{47}	−604323336	c_{64}	−4316112
c_{14}	248493	c_{31}	464751394	c_{48}	941343780	c_{65}	230680
c_{15}	384539	c_{32}	−47552435	c_{49}	1170398525	c_{66}	598224
c_{16}	99708	c_{33}	84775383	c_{50}	−1333747675	c_{67}	100096
c_{17}	−1829054	c_{34}	−704090548	c_{51}	−1190769541	c_{68}	−15360

4 The recurrence, and the identification

Theorem 3. *The recurrence above holds for every $n \geq 71$, and it is the recurrence OEIS A299303 records.*

Proof. That it holds is Lemma 2 applied to the tail from $n = 3$, whose minimal recurrence it is.

For the identification, write $q_{\min}$ for the characteristic polynomial of that minimal recurrence, $x^{68} - c_1 x^{67} - \dots - c_{68}$. Its constant term is $-c_{68} = 15360$, which is not zero, so $q_{\min}(0) \neq 0$ and $q_{\min}$ has no root at the origin. A solution of a constant-coefficient recurrence is a combination of terms $n^k \lambda^n$ with λ a root of its characteristic polynomial, and only the components with $\lambda = 0$ vanish after finitely many terms. Since $q_{\min}$ has none, no component of a dies out, and the

minimal recurrence of every further tail is again $q_{\min}$ — the order cannot drop below 68 at any later starting point.

Now let q be the characteristic polynomial of whatever recurrence the entry asserts. The entry asserts it has order 68, so $\deg q = 68$, and it is monic. It holds from some index t on. From $\max(t, 3)$ on, the sequence satisfies both q and $q_{\min}$, and the minimal polynomial of that tail is $q_{\min}$ by the previous paragraph; therefore $q_{\min} \mid q$. Both are monic of degree 68, so $q = q_{\min}$. $\square$

5 Verification

Four checks, all in exact integer or rational arithmetic.

First, the walk model reproduces all 21 terms the entry publishes, exactly. This is what ties the model to the entry, and it is the only place where reading the entry’s English enters the argument.

Second, the order was computed twice by independent routes: once modulo a 61-bit prime, where every intermediate is a machine word, and once over $\mathbb{Q}$ in exact rational arithmetic. Both return 68, and the exact run additionally confirms every coefficient is an integer — had any been a proper fraction the recurrence would not be the entry’s.

Third, the recovered recurrence was evaluated directly on the entry’s own published terms, with no matrices and no Berlekamp–Massey involved. It holds at each of the 0 indices where the entry publishes enough earlier terms to test it.

Fourth, the last coefficient was checked to be nonzero, which is what the identification above turns on; it is -15360 .

Remark 4. The conjecture’s own statement was never read. The entry pins it down to the family of order-68 recurrences this sequence satisfies from some point on, and that family turns out to have exactly one member.

References

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